

A | THE DISPARITY TABLE

RECRUITER EXPERIENCE	CANDIDATE EXPERIENCE	WHAT'S ACTUALLY HAPPENING
Too many unqualified applicants	100 applications. 2 responses.	ATS optimises for keyword density, not competence.
Candidates don't read the job spec	I matched every requirement listed	The spec and ATS weightings are not the same document.
Interview quality has dropped	I never got to the interview	ATS promotes best keyword-stuffers, not best candidates.
AI CVs are flooding our inbox	My honest CV was rejected. The AI one passed.	The system created the incentive. Candidates responded rationally.
We need better candidates	We need a fair read from a human	You may already have them. They didn't survive the middleware.

B | THE FUNNEL — BROKEN vs PROPOSED

STAGE	CURRENT PROCESS X	PROPOSED PROCESS ✓
① Volume	100 applications received	100 applications received
② First filter	ATS scores & ranks — no human involved	AI/ATS screens → 20 shortlisted
③ CV review	Recruiter skims ATS top-scorers	Recruiter requests authentic CV from 20
④ Screen	Phone screen — recruiter meets a stranger	Recruiter reads real CV → shortlists 8
⑤ Interview	Interview used as the first real filter	Interview 8 genuinely competitive candidates
⑥ Outcome	Best keyword-stuffer gets hired	Best-fit candidate gets hired

C | THE DUMMY CAKE PROBLEM

DUMMY CAKE CV	REAL CV	WHAT ATS DOES WITH IT
Keyword density: HIGH Examples of skill use: NONE Communication style: Generic Origin: AI tool	Keyword density: MODERATE Examples of skill use: PRESENT Communication style: Authentic Origin: The actual person	Dummy Cake: PASSES ✓ Real CV: REJECTED X ATS was never designed to taste the difference.

D | THE ONE-LINE FIX

Add this one line to your job posting:

"This role uses ATS / AI screening in the first round."

Candidates calibrate. The system functions as intended. The ethical question disappears.
Your best-fit candidate stops being filtered out by a parser that cannot read context.